

## Chapter 18\_1 - Blindfolded

As soon as her voice fell, the beast's roar abruptly stopped, replaced by the faint sound of sharp fangs piercing flesh. The demonic beast seemed to have lost its life before it could even groan. A thick bloody smell followed, drifting through the empty canyon.

Ning Fuyi's stomach churned. She was just reaching out to struggle when the person holding her suddenly let go and stood neatly at half a zhang<sup>1</sup> away.

As if greatly disgusted, Ning Fuyi thought with shock, not forgetting to grumble in her heart.

"Chu Qingqiu?" Ning Fuyi called out in surprise. She turned around sharply, only to see that the position where the demonic beast had stood was now empty, while a larger creature was crouching nearby, licking its paws with relish like a white cat.

Ning Fuyi had to admit that if this "white cat" wasn't twice as large as the previous demonic beast, its actions could actually be called cute.

But when it revealed bloody fangs with every lick, it could only make one's heart tremble with fear.

Ning Fuyi hurriedly stepped back two paces, unable to help covering her increasingly heavy beating heart. Ping'an on her shoulder finally broke free from its petrified state, whimpering pitifully as if scared out of its wits.

The "white cat's" gem-like brown eyes glanced sideways at Ping'an, then turned back and let out a burp full of murderous aura.

Ping'an on her shoulder suddenly whimpered and went limp, sliding down from Ning Fuyi's shoulder. Ning Fuyi's heart, which had been beating quite fast, immediately slowed by two beats. In panic, she caught Ping'an and was just turning to place it on the ground to check on it when she heard an indifferent voice from half a zhang away.

"It fainted from fright," Chu Qingqiu said.

Ning Fuyi finally breathed a sigh of relief. Her heart, which had been rising and falling dramatically, finally settled completely. She carefully found an empty spot to place Ping'an down, wiped her forehead with her hand, and only then realized she was covered in sweat from head to toe.

"How are you here?" Ning Fuyi blurted out.

She never hoped for anyone to appear, but now someone had actually come to save her, and that person was Chu Qingqiu, making her heart momentarily complex, not knowing what to say.

There was silence for half a moment before she answered: "Passing by."

After speaking, Chu Qingqiu walked to the side of that fierce "white cat" and gently stroked its fur with her delicate hand. The "white cat" whimpered once and transformed into a normal cat size amidst flying feathers all over the sky, proudly raising its tail high and lowering its head to sniff Ping'an's head.

Passing by? The Ghost Eye<sup>2</sup>, which had buried countless cultivator corpses - was it really so easy to just pass by? Ning Fuyi squinted her eyes suspiciously but said nothing more.

Regardless, Chu Qingqiu had just saved her, and Ning Fuyi had to admit that although she disliked her, no one else could make her feel so safe just by standing there.

Since it was a thigh<sup>3</sup> actively extended to her, she would condescend to hug it. Ning Fuyi's dark phoenix eyes rolled around as she immediately began calculating.

The young woman's thoughts turned a hundred times, all seen by Chu Qingqiu. Those peach blossom eyes blinked lightly and looked away.

"And why are you here? Even if those elders came down, they wouldn't survive. You, a mere Mortal Realm cultivator, don't you know how dangerous this place is?" Chu Qingqiu frowned and scolded.

"I didn't jump down myself!" Ning Fuyi bent down to pick up Ping'an, suppressing her temper as she muttered, "Who knew the Flying Eagle Boat would malfunction, and someone knocked me down..."

Before her words finished, a chill suddenly swept through her heart. When she looked up at Chu Qingqiu, she found that the other's gaze wasn't calm either.

Earlier, in the urgent situation, she hadn't thought carefully. Now, recalling it again, if it was fellow disciples on the Flying Eagle Boat who had bumped into her in panic, but later she was already being pulled by Liu Wenzhu in mid-air with no one else around - how could she have been bumped?

Could it be that someone did it deliberately?

Ning Fuyi hugged Ping'an tighter in her arms. In her previous life, she knew she wouldn't have a contracted spirit beast, so she had never come to Tongchuan, and thus this incident had never occurred.

Logically speaking, in this life she hadn't turned to evil yet, so she shouldn't have made enemies. Who could be playing tricks?

Chu Qingqiu's eyes also showed changing emotions, but she quickly returned to normal. She didn't say much more, instead changing the topic: "That was just a mid-level demonic beast, still manageable. But there are countless demonic beasts in this Ghost Eye. If we encounter something more formidable, even I would have difficulty staying alive."

"Sword flying is impossible here, so quicken your pace. We must get out before dark." Chu Qingqiu turned around, her sleeves floating past like clouds.

Seeing the "thigh" walking away, Ning Fuyi quickly held Ping'an tighter in her arms and ran after her with big steps, following closely behind.

"Which way do we go?" Ning Fuyi looked at the jagged rocks stretching endlessly before her and couldn't help asking.

"There's a secret passage at the valley bottom that leads to Tongchuan. I've placed a barrier at the passage entrance - only humans can pass through." With each step Chu Qingqiu took, glowing feathers sprouted from the soles of her feet, keeping her feet from touching the mud. Ning Fuyi looked down at her own muddy feet and couldn't help feeling envious.

"How can there be a secret passage in this ten-thousand-zhang<sup>4</sup> abyss?" Ning Fuyi asked again.

Chu Qingqiu was silent for a long while. Just when Ning Fuyi thought she wouldn't answer, she slowly spoke: "I dug it."

Ning Fuyi shivered, thinking that she was indeed worthy of being a Divine Venerable - truly formidable.

"Then why can't you dig another one now? Why must we seek that old one?" Ning Fuyi probed.

Hearing this, Chu Qingqiu looked down at her palm, then put her hands behind her back, her tone growing colder.

"Can't dig anymore," she said.

Indeed, just as she had thought. Ning Fuyi lowered her eyes. Chu Qingqiu's cultivation was damaged and couldn't recover. But she couldn't ask directly and didn't know how much strength Chu Qingqiu had left.

She also didn't know if Chu Qingqiu could persist in this valley bottom that constantly absorbed immortal energy. Ning Fuyi's hand behind her back opened slightly, but she couldn't use even half a measure of immortal power.

She could feel the evil aura gradually eroding her body, making her steps increasingly heavy. Every joint in her body felt rusty, and moving even slightly caused piercing pain. But this pain was nothing to her, so she endured it silently.

Thus, the two walked one in front and one behind, each with their own thoughts, silently for half an hour. Occasionally, some bold demonic beasts would appear, all swallowed in one gulp by the "white cat" after it resumed its original form, then it would burp contentedly and lazily transform back.

Through this back and forth, Ning Fuyi also recognized that it wasn't a white cat, but an extremely ancient divine beast - a white tiger. However, this white tiger was still young. If it matured in the future, it would be ten times more powerful than now.

This also made Ning Fuyi secretly sigh that she didn't understand Chu Qingqiu at all.

Ping'an in her arms still hadn't awakened, but its clearly arm-sized body was getting heavier and heavier, so heavy that Ning Fuyi had to grit her teeth to hold it. Her footsteps gradually became disorderly. Chu Qingqiu in front suddenly turned around, and Ning Fuyi staggered, nearly bumping into her.

Chu Qingqiu's fingertip produced a white thread that touched Ning Fuyi's wrist from a distance, seemingly checking something. After a while, she withdrew the white thread and spoke: "Bai Lin."

As soon as she finished speaking, the white cat ran over with its tail raised, transforming into a white tiger with gleaming eyes. With a sweep of its tail, Ning Fuyi found herself sitting on its fluffy back.

She hadn't expected that Chu Qingqiu wasn't as cold-hearted as she appeared on the surface. Ning Fuyi thought to herself. However, she didn't have much time to ponder why Chu Qingqiu had changed her attitude, because without immortal power to protect her body, the evil aura had already invaded her internal organs, causing knife-like pain inside her body and making her vision gradually dizzy.

Before her face fell heavily forward, her chin seemed to be supported by someone's hand. The warmth from that palm transmitted into her body, inexplicably giving her peace of mind.

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#### Footnotes:

1. **zhang (丈)**: A traditional Chinese unit of measurement, approximately 3.33 meters or 11 feet.
2. **Ghost Eye (鬼眼)**: A dangerous valley mentioned earlier, known for being extremely perilous with no survivors who enter it.
3. **thigh (大腿)**: Chinese internet slang meaning a powerful person one can depend on or "ride coattails" with.
4. **ten-thousand-zhang (万丈)**: An expression meaning extremely deep, approximately 33,330 meters or about 20 miles deep.